to secure the deal he had reached on October 28. “We discussed these issues before the full quorum of our collective leadership and our military, and all those present arrived at the unanimous conclusion that it would be reasonable to act as follows—to agree to the removal of all IL-28s from Cuba,” wrote Khrushchev to Mikoyan one day later. For him, the choice was clear: “to leave the bombers, and consequently to undermine the fulfillment of the obligations that were given on condition of the removal of the missiles … or to remove the IL-28s as we removed the missiles, but to have an agreement on noninvasion.” Khrushchev chose the latter. Now the main question was how to present his new concession to the Cubans.[4]

On Sunday, November 11, Khrushchev dictated a long letter to Mikoyan that was more a stream-of-consciousness ramble than a diplomatic instruction. Khrushchev was now much more concerned about Soviet interests and prestige than those of Cuba and the pursuit of world revolution. “What do we lose and what do we gain as a result of the removal of the IL-28s from Cuba?” he asked his long-suffering Cuban envoy. “There are no particular losses. There will only be moral losses for Cuba.” By now he was clearly distinguishing the interests of Moscow from those of Havana. “We can imagine how difficult it would be to impress such an understanding on our friends,” wrote Khrushchev in a tone sympathetic to Mikoyan before turning around and putting additional pressure on him: “But therein lies the art of politicians—when encountering difficulties, to show the ability to overcome such difficulties.”[5]

The list of “offensive weapons” passed by Adlai Stevenson to the Soviets before Mikoyan’s departure from New York on November 2 was now catching up with Mikoyan. “Half an hour before my departure from New York, those pilferers (now we are speaking about Stevenson) sent a letter to Comrade Kuznetsov, saying that they supposedly had forgotten to raise questions about some kinds of weapons,” Mikoyan told the Cuban leaders a few days later, recalling the shock he had felt on receiving the letter. He instructed the Soviet diplomats not to discuss the list—nothing but ballistic missiles had been mentioned in the correspondence between Kennedy and Khrushchev. It turned out, however, that the problem had not disappeared with Mikoyan’s departure from New York but had simply been passed on to a higher level.[6]